STUDENT WELLNESS

Exam Season Emergency Kit

Practical strategies for managing stress, staying focused, and surviving exam season

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A Note from Dr. Hala

Dear student,

Exam season can feel like the world is closing in. The pressure to perform, the fear of failure, the sleep deprivation, the comparison with classmates who seem to have it all together. I have seen this cycle in every student I work with, and I want you to know something important: your worth is not determined by a grade.

That said, I know exams matter to you. And I am not here to dismiss that. This kit gives you practical, evidence-based strategies to manage the stress, study more effectively, and take care of yourself through the process.

With warmth, **Dr. Hala Ali** *Family & Youth Counselor*

Section 1: Before the Exam Period

Plan Your Study Schedule

The single biggest mistake students make is leaving everything to the last minute. Even a rough plan reduces anxiety because your brain knows there is a structure.

1. **List all your exams** with their dates and times
2. **Work backward** from each exam date, blocking study sessions
3. **Prioritize** subjects where you need the most review
4. **Build in breaks** — your brain needs recovery time to consolidate learning
5. **Include buffer days** for unexpected setbacks

Study Schedule Worksheet

Use this template to map out your exam period. Fill in each row for every exam you have.

Exam Subject	Date & Time	Difficulty (1-5)	Study Days Needed	Start Studying By

Now block your study sessions into a weekly grid:

Time	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday
Morning					
Afternoon					
Evening					

Tip: Schedule your hardest subjects during the time of day when you are most alert. For most people, that is mid-morning. Save lighter review for evenings.

Set Up Your Study Space

- Clear your desk of everything except what you need
- Put your phone in another room or use a focus app
- Have water and snacks within reach so you do not use hunger as an excuse to stop

- Natural light is better than artificial light for focus and mood
- Keep a notepad nearby for stray thoughts so they do not pull you away from studying
- If you study at home and it is too distracting, find a library, coffee shop, or quiet corner on campus

Section 2: Study Strategies That Actually Work

Active Recall

Do not just re-read your notes. Test yourself. Cover the material and try to recall it from memory. This is uncomfortable, which is exactly why it works. Your brain strengthens connections when it has to work to retrieve information.

How to practice active recall:

- Close your notes after reading a section and write down everything you remember
- Create flashcards with a question on one side and the answer on the other
- After each study session, write a one-paragraph summary from memory
- Use practice exams under timed conditions

Spaced Repetition

Review material at increasing intervals: today, tomorrow, in three days, in a week. This is far more effective than cramming everything in one session. Your brain consolidates memory during the gaps.

Sample spaced repetition schedule:

- **Day 1:** Learn new material. Review it that evening.
- **Day 2:** Review again without looking at notes first.
- **Day 4:** Review once more. Note what you have forgotten and focus there.
- **Day 7:** Final review. By now, most of it should be in long-term memory.

The Pomodoro Technique

Study for 25 minutes. Break for 5 minutes. After four rounds, take a longer break of 15 to 30 minutes. This prevents burnout and keeps your attention sharp.

During your 5-minute break:

- Stand up and stretch
- Get water or a snack
- Look out a window (rest your eyes from the screen)
- Do not check social media — it pulls you out of study mode

Teach It to Someone

If you can explain a concept simply to someone who does not know it, you truly understand it. Find a study partner, a family member, or even explain it to yourself out loud.

The Brain Dump Method

Before you start studying for a topic, take a blank sheet of paper and write down everything you already know about that subject. Do not worry about organization. Just dump it all out. Then compare it against your notes. The gaps between what you wrote and what you need to know become your study plan.

Section 3: Managing Exam Anxiety

Before the Exam

- **Prepare your materials** the night before: pens, calculator, ID, water
- **Get at least 7 hours of sleep.** Sleep is when your brain consolidates what you studied. An all-nighter hurts more than it helps
- **Eat a proper breakfast.** Your brain runs on glucose. Do not skip meals
- **Arrive early** to avoid the panic of rushing
- **Avoid the anxious crowd.** Do not stand outside the exam room listening to classmates quiz each other. Find a quiet spot and review your own notes calmly

The Night Before the Exam Checklist

Go through this the evening before each exam:

- [ ] I have reviewed my key notes one final time (no new material tonight)
- [ ] My bag is packed: pens, pencils, eraser, calculator, ID, water bottle
- [ ] I know the exam location, room number, and start time
- [ ] I have set my alarm with a backup alarm
- [ ] I have a plan for breakfast tomorrow
- [ ] I have put my phone on Do Not Disturb
- [ ] I have done something calming before bed (reading, stretching, a warm shower)
- [ ] I am going to bed by _____ (write a time and keep it)

During the Exam

- **Read all instructions** before you start writing
- **Start with what you know** to build confidence and momentum
- **If you blank out,** close your eyes, take three deep breaths, and move to another question. The answer will often come back
- **Watch your time** but do not obsess over it
- **If you finish early,** review your answers. Do not rush to leave

The 4-7-8 Breathing Technique

If anxiety spikes during the exam:

1. Breathe in through your nose for 4 seconds
2. Hold your breath for 7 seconds
3. Breathe out slowly through your mouth for 8 seconds
4. Repeat three times

This activates your parasympathetic nervous system and physically calms you down.

The Grounding Technique (5-4-3-2-1)

If your mind starts racing and you feel panic rising during an exam:

1. Name **5 things you can see** (the desk, your pen, the clock, the window, your paper)
2. Name **4 things you can touch** (the chair, your sleeve, the table surface, your hair)
3. Name **3 things you can hear** (the clock ticking, someone writing, the air vent)
4. Name **2 things you can smell** (your eraser, the room itself)
5. Name **1 thing you can taste** (the water you just drank)

This pulls your brain out of fight-or-flight and back into the present moment. You can do this silently in your head in under a minute.

Reframe the Anxiety

A racing heart before an exam is not always a sign that something is wrong. Research shows that reframing anxiety as excitement can actually improve performance. Tell yourself: "My body is getting ready to perform. This energy is going to help me focus." It sounds simple, but it shifts your nervous system's response.

Section 4: After the Exam

What to Do

- **Do not dissect every answer** with your classmates. What is done is done
- **Take a real break** before starting to study for the next one
- **Celebrate completing it,** regardless of how you think you did
- **Move your body.** A walk, a stretch, anything to release the tension
- **Eat a proper meal.** Reward yourself with something nourishing

What Not to Do

- Do not compare yourself to others
- Do not catastrophize one bad question
- Do not skip sleep to start studying for the next exam immediately
- Do not beat yourself up. You showed up and did your best with what you had

Post-Exam Debrief Worksheet

After each exam, take 10 minutes to reflect. This is not about punishing yourself. It is about learning for the next one.

Exam subject: _____

How did I feel going into it? (1 = panicked, 5 = confident): _____

What went well?

- _____
- _____

What would I do differently next time?

- _____
- _____

What study strategies worked best for this subject?

- _____

What study strategies did not help?

- _____

One thing I am proud of about how I handled this exam:

- _____

What I need before my next exam (more sleep, earlier start, different study method):

- _____

Section 5: Surviving the Full Exam Season

The Marathon Mindset

Exam season is not a sprint. If you have multiple exams over days or weeks, pacing matters more than intensity. Here are the rules for the long haul:

- **Protect your sleep above all else.** One good night of sleep is worth more than three extra hours of studying
- **Eat real food.** Energy drinks and chips are not fuel. Your brain needs protein, healthy fats, and complex carbs
- **Move every day.** Even 15 minutes of walking changes your brain chemistry for the better
- **Stay connected.** Check in with a friend, a family member, anyone. Isolation amplifies stress
- **Give yourself grace.** Not every exam will go perfectly. That is okay. One exam does not define your semester, and one semester does not define your life

When to Ask for Help

If exam stress is becoming more than you can manage on your own, if you are having panic attacks, if you cannot sleep for days, if you feel hopeless, please reach out. Talk to a counselor, a trusted professor, or a campus support service. There is no shame in needing support during one of the most stressful periods of student life.

You are more than your grades. I believe that, and I hope by the end of exam season, you will too.

Dr. Hala Ali *Mama Hala Consulting*

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Your first conversation is free — 30 minutes, no pressure. Let's explore how counseling can help you and your family thrive.

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